

Trauma-Informed De-escalation

MODULE 1: KNOW THYSELF + CORE FOUNDATIONS

Community-centered care and dignity

Your choice

This companion is optional. Move at your own pace, skip any prompt, or use only the pages that help you prepare.

Community-centered de-escalation begins with knowing your own body, capacity, limits, and choices.

You are the most important tool you have.

1. What this training offers

This is

Skills for knowing your limits, staying grounded, reading a situation, and supporting safer interactions.

This does not replace

Clinical care, emergency services, physical-safety training, organizational procedures, or community relationships.

Training helps when it is paired with practice, resources, and people who can share the response.

Regulate. Relate. Reason.

Regulate

Attend to the body and reduce activation first.

Relate

Build enough connection for the person to feel your presence.

Reason

Problem-solving works better after the body and relationship have more steadiness.

Adapted from Bruce D. Perry's Regulate-Relate-Reason heuristic.

2. Before, during, and after

Prevention

Know yourself, your environment, your resources, and your limits.

Intervention

Choose a response that fits the moment, your role, and your capacity.

Postvention

Recover, reconnect, review what happened, and change what needs changing.

What does steady feel like?

Think of a place, person, memory, or moment when your body felt at ease.

What do you notice in your body when you feel steady?

What word or phrase captures that feeling?

3. Notice your activation

Recognition gives you more choices. Look for your earliest signs before the alarm becomes loud.

Body

Tension, heart rate, breathing, stomach, jaw, hands, temperature.

Thinking

Racing thoughts, tunnel vision, going blank, assuming the worst.

Behavior

Withdrawing, getting louder, freezing, pacing, clenching, fixing.

What are your earliest signals?

Which situations, tones, people, roles, or environments increase your activation?

4. Capacity and responsibility are different

Capacity

What you can safely handle based on your body, skills, role, support, and the conditions around you.

Responsibility

What you believe you should do, what your role requires, or what others expect from you.

Feeling responsible does not create capacity. Naming a limit can be part of a responsible response.

Hard limits

Conditions where you should not engage, such as weapons, active violence, no safe exit, or being alone without support.

Soft limits

Conditions where you need to pause and check your activation, health, authority, or available backup.

What are your hard and soft limits?

5. Scan the situation

Situation

Two people are arguing loudly near a bus stop. A parent and two children are waiting nearby.

What would you look for?

- ☐ Exits and safer spaces
- ☐ Other people affected
- ☐ Available help or witnesses
- ☐ Distance and movement
- ☐ Visible weapons or immediate danger
- ☐ What I may be assuming

Your body reads cues quickly. Listen to it and question the story you attach to the cues.

Behavior has many possible causes

Mental health distress, substance use, trauma responses, neurodivergence, disability, cultural or communication differences, pain, fear, grief, or unmet basic needs may all affect behavior.

You do not need to diagnose the cause. Respond to what is happening and leave room for what you do not know.

6. Pause before you act

What do I know?

What do I not know?

What can I do within my capacity and role?

What can I not do?

7. Find your response role

You do not need every role. Notice which options fit your strengths, limits, and safety.

Direct - Speak clearly when it is safe.

Distract - Shift attention or interrupt the pattern.

Delegate - Bring in someone with more capacity or authority.

Delay - Check in after the moment.

Document - Record safely, with attention to consent.

Escort - Walk with someone toward safety.

Buffer - Create space without physical intervention.

Exit Planner - Notice exits and help people leave.

Resource Connector - Know who to call and how to reach them.

Redirector - Move attention away from the person being targeted.

Steady Anchor - Stay grounded and offer practical support.

Narrator - Use neutral language to slow the moment.

Direct, Distract, Delegate, Delay, and Document are Right To Be's 5Ds. The additional roles are community-care applications developed or synthesized for Trauma Informed Oregon.

Which two or three could you use with the most steadiness?

8. Ask before using your role

- ☐ Am I safe enough?
- ☐ Am I already activated?
- ☐ Is there an exit?
- ☐ Do I need backup?
- ☐ Will this help or add heat?

Remember

You can switch strategies. Delayed support still matters. Calling someone else is a response. Walking away can be a community-care strategy.

Build a grounding and support plan

One action that helps me settle in under 30 seconds

One phrase I can say to myself

One person I can call or text

My first-call number for behavioral health support

9. Carry it forward

You have identified your baseline, activation signals, limits, response roles, and support plan. You decide when you are done. What matters is what you can reach for in a real moment.

What is one thing you want to practice?

Multnomah County behavioral health support

Call 503-988-4888 for support 24 hours a day. Call or text 988 for the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline. Call 911 for immediate danger, violence, fire, or emergency medical care. Crisis services may involve emergency responders when they believe there is an immediate safety risk.

Return to the interactive Community Care Resource Map for phase-specific guidance and current service links.

Sources and acknowledgments

These sources support the core frameworks used in this module. The activities and community-care applications were developed or synthesized for Trauma Informed Oregon.

Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration. Trauma-Informed Approaches and Programs.

<https://www.samhsa.gov/mental-health/trauma-violence/trauma-informed-approaches-programs>

Neurosequential Network. Disaster Support: Regulate-Relate-Reason heuristic.

<https://www.neurosequential.com/disaster-support>

Right To Be. The 5Ds of Bystander Intervention.

<https://righttobe.org/guides/bystander-intervention-training/>

Scope

This is an educational tool. It does not replace clinical care, emergency services, physical-safety training, or organizational procedures.